



PHARMACY STARTUP CHECKLIST

A practical, stage-by-stage checklist for planning, preparing and launching a retail pharmacy in India.

Business / Pharmacy Name	
Owner / Promoter	
Planned Location	
Target Opening Date	

How to use this checklist

Mark each item only after evidence is available. Maintain a separate digital folder for licences, quotations, layouts, contracts, vendor documents, staff records and launch approvals.

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Business Concept and Feasibility

Define the business model and confirm that the location and investment plan are commercially practical.

- ☐ Write a clear pharmacy concept: neighbourhood retail, clinic-linked, hospital-support, specialty, wellness-led or mixed format.
- ☐ Define the target customer segments and expected prescription sources.
- ☐ Complete a local demand assessment covering population, clinics, hospitals, competitors, footfall and delivery demand.
- ☐ Estimate the realistic monthly sales range for the first 12 months.
- ☐ Prepare a startup budget including deposit, interiors, equipment, licences, professional fees, opening inventory and working capital.
- ☐ Prepare a monthly expense estimate for rent, salaries, utilities, software, delivery, marketing and compliance.
- ☐ Calculate expected gross margin, break-even sales and minimum working-capital requirement.
- ☐ Decide the ownership structure and record roles, capital contribution and decision rights of all promoters.
- ☐ Prepare a written go/no-go decision with major risks and assumptions.

Decision checkpoint

Do not commit the full investment until the location, budget and break-even assumptions have been independently reviewed.

2

Location and Premises

Select premises that support accessibility, legal suitability, safe storage and efficient customer service.

- ☐ Confirm ownership or execute a clear lease/rent agreement with adequate tenure and permitted business use.
- ☐ Verify local access, visibility, parking/drop-off, public transport, nearby healthcare activity and delivery reach.
- ☐ Measure the usable area and prepare a scaled layout before finalising interiors.
- ☐ Plan prescription counter, billing, waiting space, storage, refrigerator, quarantine/returns area and staff utility space.
- ☐ Confirm reliable electricity, ventilation, water, drainage, internet and mobile network.
- ☐ Assess safety risks including water seepage, direct sunlight, heat, dust, pests and unauthorised access.
- ☐ Plan customer accessibility, clear signage and safe movement inside the store.
- ☐ Keep dated premises photographs, floor plan and possession documents in the project file.

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Licences, Registrations and Documentation

Create a compliance tracker and verify exact requirements with the relevant authorities and qualified professionals.

- ☐ Identify the drug licence category and application requirements applicable to the proposed pharmacy.
- ☐ Confirm availability and documentation of the registered pharmacist(s) required for operations.
- ☐ Prepare premises proof, constitution documents, identity/address proofs, declarations, photographs and layout documents.
- ☐ Check whether GST, local trade, Shops and Establishments, professional tax, labour or other registrations apply.
- ☐ Confirm requirements for biomedical waste, fire safety, signage, weights and measures or other local approvals, where applicable.
- ☐ Create a licence and registration renewal calendar with responsible person and reminder dates.
- ☐ Prepare a compliance file containing originals/copies, inspection records, correspondence and renewal evidence.
- ☐ Ensure the pharmacy does not begin regulated operations until required approvals are obtained.

Compliance note

Requirements can vary by state, premises type and business model. Verify current rules with the competent authority before filing or operating.

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Store Design, Equipment and Technology

Build an operational layout that protects product quality and allows accurate, efficient work.

- ☐ Approve final layout, elevations, electrical points, lighting, storage plan and customer flow.
- ☐ Select durable shelving and storage that supports category zoning, FEFO rotation and cleaning access.
- ☐ Install appropriate air-conditioning/ventilation and temperature monitoring arrangements.
- ☐ Procure a suitable pharmaceutical refrigerator and define temperature-recording responsibility where cold-chain products will be handled.
- ☐ Arrange computer/POS devices, barcode scanner, printer, power backup and secure internet.
- ☐ Select pharmacy software covering sales, purchase, returns, expiry, GST, inventory, user controls and reporting.
- ☐ Create role-based software access, strong passwords, backup procedures and incident reporting.
- ☐ Install security controls such as CCTV, restricted storage and cash-handling safeguards as appropriate.
- ☐ Complete equipment testing and maintain invoices, warranties and service contacts.

Vendors, Inventory and Product Assortment

Create a controlled opening stock plan that balances availability, cash flow and expiry risk.

- ☐ Prepare an approved vendor list with licences/registrations, commercial terms, return policy, delivery schedule and escalation contacts.
- ☐ Compare distributors on availability, service, credit terms, scheme transparency, expiry returns and documentation quality.
- ☐ Define opening assortment by prescription demand, chronic therapy, acute therapy, OTC, wellness, devices and local needs.
- ☐ Set initial purchase quantities using expected demand rather than supplier schemes alone.
- ☐ Define minimum, maximum and reorder levels for priority products.
- ☐ Create processes for inward verification, invoice checking, batch/expiry capture, damaged stock and discrepancies.
- ☐ Implement FEFO placement, near-expiry identification, non-moving stock review and supplier-return tracking.
- ☐ Create a separate quarantine process for damaged, expired, recalled or returned items.
- ☐ Plan opening inventory count and reconcile physical stock with the software before launch.
- ☐ Define weekly and monthly inventory reports including stock-outs, expiry exposure, dead stock and turnover.

People, SOPs and Training

Recruit qualified staff and standardise critical workflows before the first customer is served.

- ☐ Prepare an organisation chart and role descriptions for pharmacist, manager, assistant, cashier and delivery personnel as applicable.
- ☐ Verify qualifications, registration, identity, references and employment documentation before joining.
- ☐ Prepare appointment terms, attendance, leave, shift, conduct, confidentiality and performance expectations.
- ☐ Create SOPs for opening, closing, prescription handling, dispensing, billing, counselling, purchase, returns and inventory.
- ☐ Create SOPs for cold-chain products, controlled/scheduled items, recalls, complaints, incidents and data privacy as applicable.
- ☐ Train staff on product location, software, customer communication, hygiene, security and escalation procedures.
- ☐ Conduct practical mock drills for prescription processing, stock receipt, return handling and emergency situations.
- ☐ Use training checklists and competency sign-off rather than attendance alone.
- ☐ Display required notices, licences and customer information in the correct locations.

Pre-Launch, Opening and First 90 Days

Complete controlled testing before opening and review performance closely during the first three months.

- ☐ Complete a full pre-opening audit of licences, premises, equipment, software, inventory, staff and SOP readiness.
- ☐ Test billing, purchase entry, discounts, taxes, returns, credit notes, barcode scanning and end-of-day reports.
- ☐ Verify all opening stock quantities, batch numbers, expiry dates, purchase rates, MRP and selling prices.
- ☐ Confirm cash float, payment terminals, UPI, banking, invoice numbering and daily reconciliation responsibility.
- ☐ Create opening-day duty roster, escalation contacts and contingency plan for power, internet or software failure.
- ☐ Prepare ethical launch communication for nearby clinics, residents and digital channels without misleading claims.
- ☐ Confirm Google Business Profile, website, WhatsApp, contact number, delivery area and operating hours.
- ☐ Schedule daily reviews for the first week and weekly reviews for the first three months.
- ☐ Track sales, gross margin, stock-outs, expiry exposure, customer complaints, prescription conversion and cash variances.
- ☐ Review vendor performance, staff gaps, category demand and reorder levels after 30, 60 and 90 days.
- ☐ Document corrective actions, owners and deadlines after every review.

Final launch approval

The owner/promoter and responsible pharmacist should sign the launch-readiness review only after all critical items are closed or formally risk-accepted.

Launch readiness reviewed by	Date
Responsible pharmacist	Signature
Owner / authorised person	Signature

Disclaimer: This checklist is a planning and operational aid, not legal, tax, architectural or regulatory advice. Requirements change and may differ by state, local authority, premises and business model. Obtain current professional and regulatory guidance before acting.